



INFORMATION AND IDEAS

Central Ideas and Details

How to find the main idea fast — and avoid every trap built around it

What Are These Questions Asking?

Central Ideas and Details questions are pure reading comprehension. No outside knowledge, no complex reasoning — just read a short passage carefully and identify its main idea.

The Main Idea SHOULD

- Cover a majority of the details introduced in the text
- Reflect any particular points of emphasis from the passage
- Match the level of certainty the text actually uses (hedged vs. definitive)

The Main Idea Should NOT

- Focus too intently on just one supporting detail
- Introduce new ideas the passage never addresses
- Contradict information actually stated in the text

Read for Shape, Not Just Content

Most short informational passages follow a predictable shape. Learn to spot it instead of rereading.

SETUP

An assumption, a common belief, or the situation before the key finding.

ILLUSTRATION

Specific evidence, a study, or a detail that tests or supports the setup.

PIVOT + POINT

A word like 'however' or 'instead,' followed by the passage's real takeaway.

The main idea almost always lives in the setup or right after the pivot — not buried inside the illustration.

Three Steps to a Fast, Confident Answer

1

Sort the Sentences

As you read, label each sentence in your head: is it the setup, the illustration, or the pivot/point?

2

Predict First

Before reading choices, state the main idea in one plain sentence — combine the setup and the point.

3

Eliminate by Trap Type

Check each choice: is it too narrow, does it invent new information, or does it contradict the text?

Tree Rings & Climate Records

A dendrochronologist spent six years cross-referencing tree-ring samples from a remote forest with regional flood records, initially expecting only to confirm known drought years. Instead, the ring widths revealed three previously undocumented flood events from the 1600s that had left no trace in written records. The finding suggests that written historical records of extreme weather in the region are far less complete than researchers had assumed.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A. A dendrochronologist spent six years studying tree-ring samples from a remote forest.

C. Written historical records are always less reliable than natural evidence like tree rings.

B. Cross-referencing tree rings with flood records revealed undocumented floods, suggesting written weather records are more incomplete than assumed. ✓

D. The forest studied had experienced three major floods during the 1600s.

Why: The main idea must cover the passage's central arc — what was studied, what was found, and what that finding implies — not just one piece of that arc in isolation. Choice C is the most commonly picked wrong answer — it sounds like a reasonable extension of the passage's point, but it overstates a single case into an absolute, universal claim ('always less reliable') that the passage never makes.

Octopus Camouflage Mechanism

Marine biologists long assumed that octopuses change color exclusively for camouflage, using specialized skin cells to match their surroundings. Recent high-speed video analysis, however, revealed that octopuses also flash rapid color patterns during confrontations with other octopuses, seemingly as a form of visual communication unrelated to blending into the environment. Researchers now believe color change in octopuses serves at least two distinct biological functions.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A. Octopuses use specialized skin cells to change color and match their surroundings.

B. High-speed video analysis is the most effective method for studying octopus behavior.

C. New evidence indicates octopus color change serves communicative purposes in addition to camouflage. ✓

D. Octopuses flash rapid color patterns exclusively when confronting other octopuses.

Why: When a passage sets up an old assumption and then presents new evidence that adds to or revises it, the main idea is the revised, more complete picture — not just the old assumption or just the new detail alone. Choice A is tempting because it's a true, real statement from the passage — but it's only the OLD assumption being complicated, not the passage's actual point, which is that this assumption was incomplete.

Bridge Load-Bearing Discovery

Structural engineers inspecting a century-old railway bridge expected to find that its riveted iron trusses had gradually weakened under decades of increasing train weights. Metallurgical testing instead showed the trusses had actually gained tensile strength over time, likely due to a slow crystalline change in the iron's internal structure under repeated stress. The discovery is prompting engineers to reconsider assumptions used to estimate the remaining lifespan of similar aging structures worldwide.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A. Engineers inspected a century-old railway bridge made of riveted iron trusses.

C. Train weights on the railway bridge have increased significantly over the past century.

B. An unexpected finding about aging iron trusses is prompting engineers to revise how they estimate the lifespan of similar structures. ✓

D. All aging iron structures gain tensile strength over time under repeated stress.

Why: The main idea should capture the passage's full arc: the expectation, the surprising finding that overturned it, and the broader consequence — not just the setup or an overstated version of the finding. Choice D is the most commonly picked wrong answer — it takes the specific finding about ONE bridge and incorrectly generalizes it to 'all aging iron structures,' which the passage never claims.

Urban Pollinator Corridors

City planners initially designed strips of wildflowers along highway medians primarily to reduce mowing costs and improve roadside aesthetics. Five years of insect population surveys along these corridors, however, showed a marked increase in native bee species compared to unplanted medians nearby, leading several cities to now design median plantings specifically to support declining pollinator populations.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A. City planners wanted to reduce mowing costs along highway medians.

B. Wildflower medians originally planted for other reasons proved to unexpectedly benefit pollinator populations, changing how cities plan them. ✓

C. Native bee species are currently experiencing serious population declines in most cities.

D. Every highway median in the country now contains a dedicated wildflower planting.

Why: When a passage describes an original purpose, an unexpected finding, and a resulting change in practice, the main idea must include all three elements — not just the starting motivation. Choice A is tempting because it's the passage's true opening detail, but it only captures the ORIGINAL motivation — missing the actual point of the passage, which is the unexpected finding and its consequence.

Medieval Manuscript Pigment Analysis

Conservators restoring a medieval illuminated manuscript assumed its vivid blue pigment was made from lapis lazuli, an expensive imported stone commonly used by wealthy patrons of the era. Chemical analysis instead revealed the pigment was a cheaper, locally sourced mineral chemically altered to mimic lapis lazuli's appearance, suggesting the manuscript's patron may have been of more modest means than previously believed.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A. Lapis lazuli was a common and expensive pigment used by wealthy patrons in medieval times.

B. Chemical analysis revealed a substitute pigment in the manuscript, suggesting its patron's wealth was overestimated. ✓

C. Conservators are currently restoring a medieval illuminated manuscript.

D. The manuscript's patron was definitively a person of very limited financial means.

Why: The main idea should reflect the passage's actual finding and its precise implication — not overstate a suggestion ('may have been') into a certainty, and not just restate the initial assumption. Choice D is the most commonly picked wrong answer — it takes the passage's cautious, hedged suggestion ('may have been... more modest') and incorrectly states it as a definitive fact.

Silent Film Soundtrack Rediscovery

Film archivists long believed that most silent-era films were screened with no consistent musical accompaniment, relying on whatever a local theater's pianist chose to improvise. A newly uncovered cache of distributor cue sheets, however, shows that major studios provided detailed, scene-by-scene musical instructions to theaters nationwide, indicating a far more standardized silent-film soundtrack practice than historians had previously recognized.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A. Silent films were typically accompanied by a local theater pianist improvising music.

B. A collection of newly found cue sheets reveals that silent-film music was more standardized across theaters than historians believed. ✓

C. Major film studios no longer provide any musical instructions to theaters today.

D. The newly discovered cue sheets contain scene-by-scene musical instructions.

Why: The main idea must capture the shift the passage describes — old belief versus new evidence and what that evidence implies — not just restate the old belief or just one detail about the new evidence. Choice D is tempting because it's a true, specific detail drawn directly from the passage, but it doesn't capture the broader IMPLICATION of that detail — that historians' overall understanding of silent-film practice was incomplete.

Coral Spawning Synchronization

Marine researchers studying a reef ecosystem had assumed coral spawning times were governed primarily by water temperature, since spawning across different reef systems seemed to loosely track seasonal warming. Multi-year observation of a single reef, however, found that coral colonies spawned within the same narrow one-hour window every year regardless of year-to-year temperature fluctuations, pointing instead to moonlight intensity as the primary synchronizing cue.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A. Coral spawning times vary widely and unpredictably from year to year.

B. Water temperature has no relationship whatsoever to coral reef spawning behavior.

C. Multi-year observation suggests moonlight, not temperature, is the primary factor synchronizing coral spawning. ✓

D. Researchers studied a single reef ecosystem over the course of several years.

Why: When a passage tests an assumed cause against a more precise, sustained observation, the main idea is the CORRECTED explanation the evidence points to — not a flat denial of any role for the original factor, and not just the method used. Choice B is the most commonly picked wrong answer — it overstates the passage's finding into an absolute denial that temperature matters at all, when the passage only shows moonlight is the PRIMARY cue, not the only possible factor.

Handloom Weaving Revival

Textile historians had generally assumed that industrial power looms fully replaced handloom weaving in a particular region by the early 1900s, based on factory production records showing a steep decline in handloom textile output. Oral history interviews with descendants of local weaving families, however, revealed that handloom weaving persisted as a widespread practice for home use and small local markets well into the 1950s, simply outside the commercial records historians had relied on.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A. Industrial power looms were significantly more efficient than traditional handlooms.

C. Textile historians have thoroughly documented the complete history of handloom weaving in the region.

B. Oral history evidence shows handloom weaving persisted decades longer than commercial records suggested, revealing a gap in the historical record. ✓

D. Handloom weaving for home use was more common than commercial handloom production.

Why: The main idea should reflect the passage's central correction: what the commercial records seemed to show, and what the oral histories reveal was actually missing from that picture. Choice C is tempting because it sounds like a natural, positive-sounding conclusion, but it's the OPPOSITE of the passage's point — the passage reveals historians' documentation was incomplete, not thorough.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

Three Things to Remember

1

Sort sentences as you read: setup, illustration, or pivot/point — the main idea lives in the setup or right after the pivot.

2

Predict the main idea in one plain sentence before you look at any choice.

3

Eliminate using the three trap types: too narrow, invents new information, or contradicts the text.